

The South West Africa People's Organisation (SWAPO ; Afrikaans: Suidwes-Afrikaanse Volks Organisasie, SWAVO; German: Südwestafrikanische Volksorganisation, SWAVO), officially known as the SWAPO Party of Namibia, is a political party and former independence movement in Namibia (formerly South West Africa). Founded in 1960, it has been the governing party in Namibia since the country achieved independence in 1990. The party continues to be dominated in number and influence by the Ovambo ethnic group.

SWAPO held a two-thirds majority in parliament from 1994 to 2019. In the general election held in November 2019, the party won 65.5% of the popular vote and 63 out of the 104 seats in the National Assembly. It also holds 28 out of the 42 seats in the National Council. From November 2017 until his death in February 2024, Namibian President Hage Geingob remained the president of SWAPO after being elected to the position at the party's electoral congress.

History

Background and foundation

German South West Africa was established in 1884. After World War I, the League of Nations gave South West Africa, formerly a German colony, to the United Kingdom as a mandate under the administration of South Africa. When the National Party won the 1948 election in South Africa and subsequently introduced apartheid legislation, these laws were also applied to South West Africa which was considered the de facto fifth province of South Africa.

SWAPO was founded on 19 April 1960 as the successor of the Ovamboland People's Organization. Leaders renamed the party to show that it represented all Namibians. But, the organisation had its base among the Ovambo people of northern Namibia, who constituted nearly half the total population.

Struggle for independence

During 1962, SWAPO had emerged as the dominant nationalist organisation for the Namibian

people. It co-opted other groups such as the South West Africa National Union (SWANU), and later in 1976 the Namibia African People's Democratic Organisation. SWAPO used guerrilla tactics to fight the South African Defence Force. On 26 August 1966, the first major clash of the conflict took place, when a unit of the South African Police, supported by the South African Air Force, exchanged fire with SWAPO forces. This date is generally regarded as the start of what became known in South Africa as the Border War.

One important factor in the fight for independence was the 1971-72 Namibian contract workers strike, which fought for the elimination of the contract labour system and independence from South Africa. An underlying goal was the promotion of independence under SWAPO leadership.

In 1973, the United Nations General Assembly recognised SWAPO as the 'sole legitimate representative' of Namibia's people. The Norwegian government began giving aid directly to SWAPO in 1974.

The country of Angola gained its independence on 11 November 1975 following its war for independence. The leftist Popular Movement for the Liberation of Angola (MPLA), supported by Cuba and the Soviet Union, came to power. In March 1976, the MPLA offered SWAPO bases in Angola for launching attacks against the South African military.

Independent Namibia

When Namibia gained its independence in 1990, SWAPO became the dominant political party. Though the organisation rejected the term South West Africa and preferred to use Namibia, the organisation's original name—derived from the territory's old name—was too deeply rooted in the independence movement to be changed. However, the original full name is no longer used; only the acronym remains. SWAPO, and with it much of Namibia's government and administration, continues to be dominated by the Ovambo ethnic group, despite "considerable efforts to counter [that] perception".

SWAPO president Sam Nujoma was declared Namibia's first President after SWAPO won the inaugural election in 1989. A decade later, Nujoma had the constitution changed so he could run for a third term in 1999, as it limits the presidency to two terms.

In 2004, the SWAPO presidential candidate was Hifikepunye Pohamba, described as Nujoma's hand-picked successor. In 2014, the SWAPO presidential candidate was Hage Geingob, who was the vice-president of SWAPO. In 2019 presidential election, president Geingob won his second five-year term as Namibian president.

Ideology

SWAPO was founded with the aim of attaining the independence of Namibia and therefore is part of the African nationalist movement. Pre-independence it had a socialist, Marxist–Leninist ideology, which was not immediately abandoned when independence was achieved in 1990 and SWAPO became the ruling party. Officially, however, it adopted a social democratic ideology, until the electoral congress in 2017 approved the official change to socialism with a "Namibian character", although some Namibians have labelled the change as lacking a "grass-roots" nature.

Various commentators have characterised the politics of SWAPO in different ways. Gerhard Tötemeyer, himself a party member, considered its post-independence politics neoliberal and social democratic. Henny Seibeb, an opposition politician from the Landless People's Movement, describes the current party ideology as liberal nationalism with traces of "dogmatism, authoritarianism, and statism".

Structure

The party president is the top position of SWAPO; in 2012 this was held by Namibia's former president Pohamba. The vice-president was Namibia's former president Hage Geingob, who was elected to that position in 2007 and reconfirmed at the SWAPO congress in December

2012, until his death on 4 February 2024. The third highest position in SWAPO is the secretary-general, a position held in December 2012 by Nangolo Mbumba. Number four is the deputy secretary-general, Omaheke governor Laura McLeod-Katjirua.

Like many socialist and communist parties, SWAPO is governed by a politburo and a central committee. The party leadership is advised by a youth league, a women's council, and an elders' council.

Politburo

The politburo of SWAPO is a body that currently consists of 29 members for the period 2022–2027 (including party president, former party president, secretary general, deputy secretary general, members appointed by the party president and members elected by the SWAPO central committee for the period).

Central Committee

SWAPO's Central Committee consists of:

The president

The vice-president

The secretary-general

The deputy secretary-general

The founding president of SWAPO as a permanent member

13 SWAPO Party regional coordinators

54 members elected at the party congress

10 members appointed by the party president

The current 100 Central Committee members are:

List of presidents

Sam Nujoma (1960–2007)

Hifikepunye Pohamba (2007–2015)

Hage Geingob (2015–2024)

Finances and business interests

Although SWAPO receives finances from government for its operations, the party also holds extensive business interests. Through Kalahari Holdings, it entered into joint ventures with several companies, most prominently the Namibian branch of MultiChoice, a private satellite TV provider, of which it owns 51%. Kalahari Holdings has further joint ventures with Radio Energy, Africa Online, and businesses in the tourism, farming, security services and health insurance sectors. It owns Namib Contract Haulage, Namprint, Kudu Investments and the Ndilimani Cultural Troupe.

SWAPO also runs Guinas Investments (Pty) Ltd, which owns 96.5% of Gendev Fishing Resources (Pty) Ltd. The latter in turn owns 60% of the Gendev Fishing Group joint venture. Former Minister of Fisheries and Marine Resources Helmut Angula, himself running a fishing company, described SWAPO's business structure as "deliberately structured to be complex, multi-layered and opaque".

Namibia Today was the mouthpiece of the SWAPO, and Asser Ntinda was its editor. The paper does not appear to have been active since 7 April 2011 and closed down in 2015.

Human rights abuses

Various groups have claimed that SWAPO committed serious human rights abuses against suspected spies during the independence struggle. Since the early 21st century, they have pressed the government more strongly on this issue. Breaking the Wall of Silence (BWS) is one of the groups founded by people who were detained by SWAPO during the war and abused

during interrogations. In 2004, BWS alleged that "In exile, hundreds of SWAPO dependants and members were detained, tortured and killed without trial." SWAPO denies serious infractions and claims anything that did happen was in the name of liberation. Because of a series of successful South African raids, the SWAPO leadership believed that spies existed in the movement. Hundreds of SWAPO cadres were imprisoned, tortured and interrogated.

Memberships

SWAPO is a full member of Socialist International. It was a member of the Non-Aligned Movement before the independence of Namibia in 1990.

Electoral history

Presidential elections

National Assembly elections

National Council elections

See also

Ovamboland People's Organization

People's Liberation Army of Namibia

South West Africa National Union

Caprivi African National Union

Democratic Turnhalle Alliance

Namibia African People's Democratic Organisation

Popular Movement for the Liberation of Angola

South African Border War

SWAPO Democrats

SWAPO for Justice

1971–72 Namibian contract workers strike

Namibian Czechs

References

External links

Official website

Example SWAPO Party Youth League web page. "Latest from the SPYL Frontlines". spyl.swapo.party. SWAPO Party Youth League. 28 August 2012. Archived from the original on 28 August 2012. Retrieved 7 November 2024.

Secondary literature

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